pro-Khalistan separatist, Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, in New York, and the sudden movement on both issues is a concerted push by the two to corner India. That they shared intelligence on the Nijjar case was acknowledged by Trudeau in his press conference. On October 15, Canada briefed its other Five Eyes partners, the UK and New Zealand, about the probe. That day, the US state department came out in support of Canada, saying the allegations against India "needed to be taken seriously". "We wanted to see the Indian government cooperate with Canada...they have not chosen that path," it stated.

Though India has aggressively engaged Canada in denying any link with Nijjar's killing, it has taken a more cooperative approach with the US in the Pannun case. In November 2023, the US department of justice had alleged that an Indian government employee was behind the plot; US officials also arrested an Indian citizen, Nikhil Gupta, who allegedly hired a hitman to kill Pannun. India had promptly formed a probe team to investigate the US charges; it is currently visiting the US to discuss the case with authorities there.

Future Tense

With regard to the way forward, experts counsel caution. Ajay Bisaria, former Indian high commissioner to Canada, tells INDIA TODAY that Canada's actions do constitute an "overreach" and "needless escalation". Bisaria believes that "India does not want to escalate the matter further and does not want to damage its long-term relations with Canada".

Finding a way out of the diplomatic imbroglio is going to be difficult as the two sides put out starkly different narratives. The first allegation about Indian involvement in Nijjar's killing was made in September 2023, just after Trudeau attended the G20 Leaders' Summit in New Delhi, with the Canadian PM saying it openly in the nation's parliament. Though Canada has repeatedly said it has provided India with "irrefutable evidence" of Indian government agents' links with the crime, India maintains that Canada didn't provide "a shred of evidence".

More recently, on October 14, the Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP) alleged that "agents" of the Indian government, including diplomats, were using organised criminal elements—the Lawrence Bishnoi gang was named—to spread terror in Canada, targeting Canadian citizens from "the South Asian community, specifically pro-Khalistani elements". Supporting the RCMP findings, Trudeau stated that India made a "fundamental error" by "supporting criminal activities against Canadians on Canadian soil" for which there was "clear and compelling evidence". The MEA went ballistic in its response, saying, "The responsibility for the damage that this cavalier behaviour has caused India-Canada relations lies with...Trudeau."

There is some basis in India blaming Trudeau the politician for the current crisis. His repeated allegations against India coincide with his sliding popularity ratings, recent parliamentary bypoll losses for his ruling Liberal Party in Toronto and Montreal, calls for him to resign before the 2025 federal polls and his government's narrow survival in a second parliamentary confidence vote last week. With the New Democratic Party led by pro-Khalistani Jagmeet Singh withdrawing support from his government, a desperate Trudeau must curry favour with Canada's 770,000-strong Sikh community—many of them Khalistani sympathisers—for survival.

For both India and Canada, resolving this issue means avoiding public recrimination and building trust through quiet negotiation. At stake is a relationship built over decades between two countries that are on the same side of the fight for recognised global principles and rule of law.

Looking ahead, experts believe that as long as Trudeau remains in power, normalcy between India and Canada is unlikely. The outcome of the 2025 Canadian election will be crucial in determining India's future approach towards the country. If Trudeau wins against the run of play, India will need to reassess its strategy. ■

THE ROW OVER NIJJAR

How India-Canada ties went into free fall over the case



June 2023

Hardeep Singh Nijjar, a Canadian Sikh Khalistani, killed in Surrey, British Columbia

Sept. 2023

Canadian PM Justin Trudeau says intelligence agencies probing links between Indian agents and Nijjar's assassination

Canada expels an Indian diplomat; India expels a Canadian one, citing "interference in internal matters"

Oct. 2023

Canada pulls out 41 diplomats from India after New Delhi revokes their diplomatic immunity

May 2024

The Royal Canadian Mounted Police arrests four Indians for Nijjar's murder. In all, 30 arrested

Aug. 2024

Canadian police warn Nijjar aide Inderjeet Singh Gosal of a threat to his life

Oct. 2024

Canada expels 6 Indian diplomats, says they are 'persons of interest' in Nijjar case; India expels six Canadian diplomats